

DBT SKILLS WORKBOOK FOR ADULTS

Managing Intense Emotions & Relationships

Distress Tolerance | Emotion Regulation
Interpersonal Effectiveness | Mindfulness

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Evidence-Based DBT Skills & Worksheets

DBT Skills Workbook for Adults

Managing Intense Emotions & Relationships

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UNDERSTANDING EMOTIONAL DYSREGULATION

Emotional dysregulation means your emotions are MORE INTENSE, come on FASTER, and take LONGER to return to baseline than other people's.

This is not a character flaw. It is a biological difference in how your nervous system processes emotional stimuli.

THE BIOSOCIAL THEORY:

Biology: You were born with a more sensitive emotional system
+ Environment: Your emotions were invalidated ('You're overreacting')
= Difficulty regulating emotions as an adult

WHAT DYSREGULATION LOOKS LIKE:

- Emotions go from 0 to 100 in seconds
- Small events trigger overwhelming reactions
- Difficulty calming down once upset
- Impulsive behaviors to escape pain (spending, substances, self-harm)
- Relationships feel all-or-nothing (idealize/devalue)
- Chronic feelings of emptiness
- Identity confusion ('Who am I really?')

DBT teaches four skill sets to manage this:

1. MINDFULNESS - Being present without judgment
2. DISTRESS TOLERANCE - Surviving crisis without making it worse
3. EMOTION REGULATION - Reducing vulnerability & changing emotions
4. INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS - Getting needs met in relationships

WISE MIND MEDITATION

Wise Mind is the overlap of EMOTION MIND and REASONABLE MIND.

EMOTION MIND: Ruled by feelings. Hot, reactive, impulsive.

REASONABLE MIND: Ruled by logic. Cold, rational, disconnected.

WISE MIND: Both. Intuitive knowing. Calm certainty.

MEDITATION SCRIPT 1: FINDING WISE MIND

Close your eyes. Take three slow breaths.

Imagine walking down a spiral staircase, going deeper with each step.

At the bottom is a pool of still water - this is your Wise Mind.

Look into the water. What do you see? What do you know to be true?

Your Wise Mind already has the answer. Listen.

When ready, slowly walk back up the staircase.

MEDITATION SCRIPT 2: STONE ON THE LAKE

Imagine you are a flat stone thrown onto a lake.

You skim the surface (Emotion Mind - reactive, choppy).

Then you begin to sink slowly, gently, down through the water.

Deeper... quieter... calmer...

You settle on the bottom of the lake. Still. Clear. Certain.

This is Wise Mind. Rest here.

Today I am in: ☐ Emotion Mind ☐ Reasonable Mind ☐ Wise Mind

What does my Wise Mind say about my current situation?

OBSERVE & DESCRIBE: NON-JUDGMENTAL STANCE

OBSERVE = Notice without reacting. See it like a camera.

DESCRIBE = Put words on it without adding judgment.

JUDGMENTAL: 'He's a terrible person for ignoring me'

NON-JUDGMENTAL: 'He did not respond to my text within 2 hours'

PRACTICE: Rewrite these judgments as non-judgmental observations:

'I'm such an idiot' -->

'She's so selfish' -->

'This day is ruined' -->

'I can't handle anything' -->

MY JUDGMENTS TODAY:

Judgment: _____

Non-judgmental rewrite: _____

Judgment: _____

Non-judgmental rewrite: _____

DISTRESS TOLERANCE: TIPP SKILLS

When emotions are at 7+ out of 10, use TIPP to bring them down FAST.

These work with your body's nervous system to reduce arousal.

T = TEMPERATURE (Ice Diving)

Hold ice cubes in hands, splash ice water on face, or hold a frozen bag on cheeks/neck. This triggers the dive reflex and slows heart rate.

Duration: 30-60 seconds. Intensity drops 2-3 points quickly.

I = INTENSE EXERCISE

Sprint, jump, do burpees, run stairs - anything to burn adrenaline.

Duration: 10-20 minutes of vigorous movement.

This metabolizes stress hormones your body released.

P = PACED BREATHING

Breathe out LONGER than you breathe in.

In for 4... Out for 6... In for 4... Out for 6...

This activates the parasympathetic (calming) nervous system.

Duration: 5-10 minutes minimum.

P = PAIRED MUSCLE RELAXATION

Tense each muscle group while breathing in.

Release tension while breathing out and saying 'relax' silently.

Work through: hands, arms, shoulders, face, chest, stomach, legs, feet.

MY TIPP PLAN (fill in before a crisis happens):

Ice location: _____

Exercise I can do quickly: _____

Breathing technique I'll use: _____

THE STOP SKILL & REALITY ACCEPTANCE

THE STOP SKILL (use BEFORE you react impulsively):

S = STOP. Freeze. Do not move. Do not react.

T = TAKE A STEP BACK. Remove yourself physically or mentally.

O = OBSERVE. What am I feeling? What happened? What are the facts?

P = PROCEED MINDFULLY. Ask Wise Mind: What action will I not regret?

PRACTICE: Last time I reacted impulsively:

What happened: _____

What I did: _____

What STOP would have looked like: _____

REALITY ACCEPTANCE WORKSHEET:

Radical Acceptance does NOT mean approval. It means acknowledging what IS, so you can respond effectively instead of fighting reality.

The reality I am struggling to accept:

What I wish were true instead:

The cost of NOT accepting (how does fighting reality hurt me?):

I can accept this reality AND still:

Turning the Mind: I choose to accept (even if I have to choose again):

TURNING THE MIND EXERCISE

Acceptance is not a one-time choice. You may need to 'turn the mind' toward acceptance 100 times a day. Each time you notice you've drifted back into non-acceptance, gently turn back. Like training a puppy.

WILLINGNESS vs WILLFULNESS:

WILLINGNESS: Doing what works. Responding to the situation as it is.

WILLFULNESS: Refusing to accept. Sitting on your hands. Giving up.

Signs I am being WILLFUL right now:

- ☐ Refusing to do what I know works
- ☐ Giving up / 'What's the point'
- ☐ Trying to control what I cannot control

What willingness would look like in this situation:

HALF-SMILE & WILLING HANDS (body-based acceptance):

Turn palms UP. Relax fingers. Slightly lift corners of mouth.

This posture sends signals to your brain: 'I am open. I accept.'

Practice for 2 minutes while thinking about the difficult reality.

After practicing, distress level (0-10): _____

EMOTION REGULATION: BUILDING MASTERY

Building Mastery means doing something DIFFICULT each day to build confidence and a sense of competence. Start small, increase gradually.

Rules: 1) It should be slightly challenging 2) Match to current mood
3) It does NOT have to be productive - learning counts!

MASTERY IDEAS BY DIFFICULTY LEVEL:

Easy: Make bed, send one email, cook a simple meal, organize one drawer

Medium: Exercise 20 min, learn something new, complete work task

Hard: Have a difficult conversation, try something scary, set a boundary

MY BUILDING MASTERY PLAN THIS WEEK:

Monday:	_____	Done?	☐
Tuesday:	_____	Done?	☐
Wednesday:	_____	Done?	☐
Thursday:	_____	Done?	☐
Friday:	_____	Done?	☐
Saturday:	_____	Done?	☐
Sunday:	_____	Done?	☐

COPE AHEAD WORKSHEET

Cope Ahead means rehearsing how you will handle a difficult situation BEFORE it happens. Like a mental fire drill.

STEP 1: Describe the situation (who, what, where, when):

STEP 2: What emotions am I likely to feel?

STEP 3: What urges might I have (that I want to avoid)?

STEP 4: What DBT skills will I use?

STEP 5: Imagine the scene going WELL. Visualize yourself:

- Using your skills
- Managing emotions without making things worse
- Feeling the emotion AND still acting effectively

STEP 6: After the event - what actually happened?

ACCUMULATING POSITIVES

SHORT-TERM: Do one pleasant thing each day. Build a life worth living.

My pleasant activities list (things that bring even small joy):

LONG-TERM: Work toward goals that give life MEANING.

Values I want to live by:

One long-term goal aligned with my values:

Next small step toward this goal:

When will I take this step?

INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS: DEAR MAN

DEAR MAN = Getting what you NEED while keeping self-respect.

D = DESCRIBE the situation (facts only, no judgments)

E = EXPRESS how you feel ('I feel...when...because...')

A = ASSERT what you want (ask clearly, say no clearly)

R = REINFORCE (explain the positive outcome for them too)

M = MINDFUL (stay on topic, don't get distracted)

A = APPEAR CONFIDENT (eye contact, steady voice, stand tall)

N = NEGOTIATE (be willing to give to get)

MY DEAR MAN SCRIPT (fill in for your situation):

Describe:

Express:

Assert:

Reinforce:

What I am willing to negotiate on:

INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS: GIVE

GIVE = Building and maintaining RELATIONSHIPS.

G = GENTLE (no attacks, threats, or judging)

- No 'you always' or 'you never'
- No name-calling, even in your head
- No physical intimidation or door-slamming

I = INTERESTED (listen! ask questions, lean in)

- Put phone down. Make eye contact.
- Reflect back: 'So what you're saying is...'

V = VALIDATE (acknowledge their feelings are real)

- 'I can see why you'd feel that way'
- 'That makes sense given your experience'
- Validation does NOT mean agreement

E = EASY MANNER (lighten up, smile, use humor)

- Not everything has to be heavy
- Softening your approach gets better results

PRACTICE: A relationship I want to improve:

One GIVE skill I will practice this week:

What happened when I used it:

INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS: FAST

FAST = Maintaining SELF-RESPECT in interactions.

F = FAIR (be fair to yourself AND the other person)

- Don't over-apologize. Don't be a doormat.
- Don't bully. Both people matter equally.

A = APOLOGIES (no unnecessary apologizing)

- Stop saying sorry for existing, having needs, or taking space
- Only apologize when you've actually done wrong

S = STICK TO VALUES (don't compromise your integrity)

- Don't agree to things that violate your values
- Don't lie or act helpless to get what you want

T = TRUTHFUL (don't exaggerate, lie, or manipulate)

- Be honest even when it's uncomfortable
- State your truth calmly and directly

SAYING NO WITH FAST:

Situation requiring no: _____

My honest, fair response: _____

Did I apologize unnecessarily? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Did I stay true to my values? ☐ Yes ☐ No

WALKING THE MIDDLE PATH

Black-and-white thinking creates suffering. The middle path is BOTH/AND.

Instead of ALL or NOTHING, find the synthesis:

'People are either good or bad'

MIDDLE: People are complex and can be both caring AND hurtful

'If they loved me they'd never hurt me'

MIDDLE: People can love you AND still make mistakes

'I either have total control or no control'

MIDDLE: I can influence some things while accepting others

MY BLACK-AND-WHITE THOUGHTS:

Extreme thought 1: _____

Middle path: _____

Extreme thought 2: _____

Middle path: _____

Extreme thought 3: _____

Middle path: _____

VALIDATION EXERCISES

Validation = communicating that someone's experience makes sense.

6 LEVELS OF VALIDATION:

Level 1: BE PRESENT (put phone down, make eye contact, listen)

Level 2: REFLECT (repeat back what they said accurately)

Level 3: MIND-READ (guess the emotion: 'Sounds like you're frustrated')

Level 4: UNDERSTAND CAUSES ('Given what happened, that makes sense')

Level 5: NORMALIZE ('Anyone would feel that way in this situation')

Level 6: RADICAL GENUINENESS (treat them as capable, not fragile)

SELF-VALIDATION PRACTICE:

My emotion right now: _____

Level 4 (understanding causes): This makes sense because:

Level 5 (normalizing): Anyone would feel this way because:

VALIDATING OTHERS PRACTICE:

Person: _____ What they expressed: _____

My validating response:

Their reaction when I validated:

DBT WEEKLY DIARY CARD - Week 1

EMOTIONS (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Sadness							
Anger							
Fear							
Shame							
Joy							

URGES (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Self-harm							
Substance							
Binge/purge							
Quit therapy							

SKILLS USED (check):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Mindfulness	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Distress Tol.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Emotion Reg.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Interpersonal	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Most helpful skill this week: _____

Biggest challenge: _____

What I want to work on next week: _____

DBT WEEKLY DIARY CARD - Week 2

EMOTIONS (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Sadness							
Anger							
Fear							
Shame							
Joy							

URGES (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Self-harm							
Substance							
Binge/purge							
Quit therapy							

SKILLS USED (check):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Mindfulness							
Distress Tol.							
Emotion Reg.							
Interpersonal							

Most helpful skill this week:

Biggest challenge:

What I want to work on next week:

DBT WEEKLY DIARY CARD - Week 3

EMOTIONS (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Sadness							
Anger							
Fear							
Shame							
Joy							

URGES (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Self-harm							
Substance							
Binge/purge							
Quit therapy							

SKILLS USED (check):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Mindfulness	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Distress Tol.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Emotion Reg.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Interpersonal	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Most helpful skill this week: _____

Biggest challenge: _____

What I want to work on next week: _____

DBT WEEKLY DIARY CARD - Week 4

EMOTIONS (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Sadness							
Anger							
Fear							
Shame							
Joy							

URGES (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Self-harm							
Substance							
Binge/purge							
Quit therapy							

SKILLS USED (check):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Mindfulness							
Distress Tol.							
Emotion Reg.							
Interpersonal							

Most helpful skill this week:

Biggest challenge:

What I want to work on next week:

DBT WEEKLY DIARY CARD - Week 5

EMOTIONS (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Sadness							
Anger							
Fear							
Shame							
Joy							

URGES (rate 0-5):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Self-harm							
Substance							
Binge/purge							
Quit therapy							

SKILLS USED (check):

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Mindfulness							
Distress Tol.							
Emotion Reg.							
Interpersonal							

Most helpful skill this week:

Biggest challenge:

What I want to work on next week:

DEAR MAN PRACTICE SCRIPT #2

Situation: _____

Person I need to talk to: _____

My goal (what do I want to happen?):

DESCRIBE (facts only):

EXPRESS (I feel...when...because...):

ASSERT (what I specifically want/need):

REINFORCE (benefit to them/relationship):

NEGOTIATE (what I'm willing to compromise on):

After the conversation - how did it go?

MY DISTRESS TOLERANCE TOOLKIT

Fill this out NOW, before a crisis. When emotions are at 9/10, you cannot think clearly. Have your plan READY.

When my distress is at 5-6/10, I will:

When my distress is at 7-8/10, I will:

When my distress is at 9-10/10, I will:

People I can call in crisis:

1. Name: _____ Phone: _____

2. Name: _____ Phone: _____

3. Name: _____ Phone: _____

Things that have helped me survive past crises:

COPE AHEAD WORKSHEET #2

Upcoming difficult situation:

Emotions I expect to feel:

Urges I might have:

Skills I will use (be specific):

Visualize success - what does 'effective' look like?

Backup plan if first skills don't work:

After the event - what happened?

What worked? What would I do differently?

COPE AHEAD WORKSHEET #3

Upcoming difficult situation:

Emotions I expect to feel:

Urges I might have:

Skills I will use (be specific):

Visualize success - what does 'effective' look like?

Backup plan if first skills don't work:

After the event - what happened?

What worked? What would I do differently?

COPE AHEAD WORKSHEET #4

Upcoming difficult situation:

Emotions I expect to feel:

Urges I might have:

Skills I will use (be specific):

Visualize success - what does 'effective' look like?

Backup plan if first skills don't work:

After the event - what happened?

What worked? What would I do differently?

COPE AHEAD WORKSHEET #5

Upcoming difficult situation:

Emotions I expect to feel:

Urges I might have:

Skills I will use (be specific):

Visualize success - what does 'effective' look like?

Backup plan if first skills don't work:

After the event - what happened?

What worked? What would I do differently?
